



SEED STARTING

indoors and outdoors

from the experts at Homestead Gardens.

Why start from seed?

- Greater variety and control.
- Cost-effective for larger gardens.
- Earlier harvest for warm-season crops.



Indoor seed starting basics.

Start seeds indoors 6-10 weeks before the last frost (Delmarva average last frost: mid-April).

You'll need:

- Clean containers or trays with drainage
- Seed-starting mix (lightweight, sterile)
- Humidity dome or plastic cover
- Warmth: 65-75° F for most seeds
- Grow lights: 12-16 hours daily once sprouted

Key tip: water from the bottom (soaking in a shallow tray) to prevent damping-off disease.



Indoor timeline: Delmarva region

Tip: use a heat mat when starting peppers and tomatoes to boost germination rates.

Plant type	Start indoors	Transplant outside
tomatoes/peppers	Feb-Mar	After Apr 15 (last frost)
broccoli/cabbage	Jan-Feb	Mar-Apr
herbs	Feb-Mar	Apr-May
annual flowers	Feb-Mar	Apr-May



Direct sowing outdoors.

Some seeds prefer to start where they'll grow.

Early spring: peas, spinach, carrots, lettuce, beets

After frost: beans, corn, cucumbers, squash, sunflowers

Tip: wait until soil warms to 60° F for heat-lovers like squash and beans.



Outdoor sowing tips.

- Work in compost before planting.
- Keep seedbed consistently moist.
- Mark rows clearly.
- Thin seedlings to avoid overcrowding.



Hardening off.

Before transplanting indoor seedlings, gradually introduce them to outdoor conditions over 7-10 days.



Ready to grow?

Check out our classes and seed-starting kits in-store!

Find seeds, soil, trays, lights and expert advice at Homestead Gardens.

Visit us online at homesteadgardens.com.

